ANIMAL HANDLING (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Animal Handling is a **Wisdom** skill. It is used to **calm** or **train** an animal, or to make it adopt a certain behavior. In combat or negotiation, it is used with the **Influence** action to coax a **Beast** or a **Monstrosity**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. With the **Influence** action, you prompt a monster to do something: a **Wisdom (Animal Handling)** check to coax a Beast or Monstrosity.
2. The **default DC** is 15 or the monster's Intelligence score, whichever is higher.
3. If the request **fits its desires**, no check. If it is **repugnant**, it refuses, no check.
4. If it hesitates, the check is affected by its **attitude**: Indifferent, Friendly, or Hostile.
5. On a failure, wait **24 hours** (or the DM's duration) before trying again the same way.

⚠ Using another ability:

- The ability of a check is **decided by the situation**: the DM may pair Animal Handling with **Charisma** (calling an animal in a reassuring voice) or **Constitution** (staying calm before a hostile beast). Table rule
- The **Proficiency Bonus** applies when the skill **fits** and you are proficient.
- See the **Use cases** page.

⚠ Change from 2014

The **Influence** action is new: default DC, the monster's attitude, and a 24-hour wait after a failure. The 2014 text also cited controlling a mount during a risky maneuver, absent from the 2024 table.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The skill's name can mislead: it is mostly for **calming and guiding**, not teaching tricks. Fix: the **DM announces** what the check allows (an immediate effect or a long training) **before** the roll.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

Describe the **slow gesture**, the low voice, the outstretched hand, the animal's ears perking up before it relaxes.

Step 1 – Decide whether a roll is needed:

If the request fits the animal's desires, no roll. If it is repugnant, it refuses with no roll. A roll happens only if the animal **hesitates**.

Step 2 – Take the Influence action:

You describe how you communicate with the animal. The check is **Wisdom (Animal Handling)** to coax a Beast or Monstrosity.

Step 3 – Set the DC:

Default DC: **15** or the monster's **Intelligence** score, whichever is higher. The attitude (Indifferent, Friendly, Hostile) affects the check.

Example: a wolf (Intelligence 3): DC 15. An owlbear (Intelligence 5): DC 15. A creature with Intelligence 17: DC 17.

Step 4 – Make the roll:

d20 + Wisdom modifier + **Proficiency Bonus** if you are proficient in Animal Handling. An ally can use the **Help** action to give you **Advantage**.

Example: Mira (Wisdom +3, Proficiency +2) offers meat to a hungry wolf (DC 15). She rolls 10 + 3 + 2 = 15: success, the wolf lets her pass.

Step 5 – Resolve:

- **Success**: the monster does what is asked.
- **Failure**: wait 24 hours (or the DM's duration) before urging it the same way again.
- A 20 or a 1 on the d20 **changes nothing** on an ability check.

ANIMAL HANDLING (5E, 2024 RULES) – TABLES

Animal Handling uses in the 2024 rules:

Situation	Check and DC
Calm or train an animal, make it adopt a behavior	Wisdom (Animal Handling), DC set by the DM
Influence action: coax a Beast or Monstrosity	Wisdom (Animal Handling) **DC 15** or the monster's Intelligence (higher)
Request that fits the monster's desires	No check
Request repugnant to the monster or against its alignment	No check: refusal
Control a mount (trained to bear a rider)	No check: it acts on your Initiative (Disengage, Dodge, or Dash)

When one use case leads to another:

First check	Consequence	Next use case
Study (Nature) on a Beast	You know its behavior	Approach idea for the Influence action (table Advantage possible)
Successful Influence	The Beast does what is asked	Combat avoided, or animal as guide, scout, carrier
Failed Influence	24-hour wait	Another approach: Intimidation (Charisma)
Controlled mount	Same Initiative as the rider	Initiative sheet: mount, Dash, Disengage, Dodge
Independent mount	Own Initiative, acts alone	The DM decides its actions

Chain example: Mira studies a beast (Nature) and learns the wolf is defending its pup. She backs off and offers meat (Influence, Animal Handling). Success: the wolf backs away. Otherwise, she waits 24 hours or tries to intimidate it.

Ability + skill combinations: Table rule

*The DM decides the ability by the situation and applies proficiency if it fits. These combinations are **exceptions announced before the roll**.*

Combination	Use in play
Charisma (Animal Handling)	Attract or reassure an animal through voice and presence (a call, a song, a whistle).
Constitution (Animal Handling)	Stay motionless and calm before a hostile beast for long minutes.
Dexterity (Animal Handling)	Guide an animal with precise gestures, ride bareback, slip on a harness without frightening it.
Strength (Animal Handling)	Physically restrain a struggling animal (hold a bridle, hold back a horse).
Intelligence (Animal Handling)	Understand a training method and plan a multi-day training.

Neighboring skills:

Skill	Use in play
Wisdom (Insight)	Read an animal's intentions from its posture and gaze.
Wisdom (Survival)	Follow an animal's tracks to find it before approaching.

How to choose: Table rule

1. What does the task demand: **power, agility, endurance, mind, presence**? That gives the ability.
2. Which skill describes the **know-how**? Apply proficiency if it fits.
3. The DM **announces** the combination and the DC before the roll.

*Example: Brann (Constitution +3, Animal Handling proficiency +2) stays motionless before a bear for 5 minutes, DC 15. He rolls 9 + 3 + 2 = 14: failure, the bear grows restless. See also the **Athletics** sheet.*

Common table questions.

Can you train an animal in a single action?

No: the Influence action lets you coax an animal **in the moment**. Teaching tricks is a long training, whose length the DM sets. Table rule

Animal Handling or Nature?

Nature: knowledge (the Study action). **Animal Handling**: acting on the animal (calming, guiding, coaxing).

Does it work on a humanoid?

No: the Influence action targets a Beast or Monstrosity. For a humanoid, use Charisma (Persuasion, Intimidation...).

Do I need to speak the animal's language?

No: Persuasion and Deception require a monster that understands you; Animal Handling does not.

How many times can I retry?

After a failure, wait **24 hours** (or the DM's duration) for the same approach. A different approach is possible.

Does attitude change the roll?

Yes: the check is affected by attitude (Indifferent, Friendly, Hostile). Table suggestion: Advantage if Friendly, Disadvantage if Hostile. Table rule

Must a mount be trained?

Yes: you only control a mount trained to bear a rider. It then acts on your Initiative.

Is a 20 an automatic success?

No: on an ability check, a **20** or a **1** has no special effect.

Which features help?

Expertise doubles the Proficiency Bonus. The **Help** action gives Advantage.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

20 and 1 on a check

On an ability check, a 20 or a 1 has no special effect: no Critical Hit, no automatic failure.

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